When Suu Kyi arrived in Burma, General Ne Win had been in power for 26 years. The country was spiraling downward both economically and socially. As time progressed, Suu Kyi continued to see firsthand the suffering the Burmese population at the hands of the brutal dictatorship. At first, Suu Kyi offered to play the role of mediator between the government and students. Initially, she did not want any sort of leadership role in the ongoing rebellion.

Circumstances changed during the turbulent year of 1988. Suu Kyi's first public appearance was at the Shwedagon pagoda on August 26, 1988. According to Peter Popham's biography of Suu Kyi, *The Lady and the Peacock*, over half a million people showed up for her speech. In answering her critics, Aung San Suu Kyi stated, “It is true that I have lived abroad. It is also true that I am married to a foreigner. These facts have never interfered and will never interfere with or lessen my love and devotion for my country by any measure or degree. Another thing which people have been saying is that I know nothing of Burmese politics. The trouble is that I know too much.” (56). She called the struggle of 1988 the second struggle for national independence. Suu Kyi also called on the military to become a force that the people can place trust in, something that her father had always strived for.

The election commission met with the key NLD leaders to discuss the formation of the system. The major concern was that the current party in control, the BSPP, would have an unfair advantage by already being entrenched within Burmese society. Furthermore, the manpower and financial advantages of the BSPP were obvious. The NLD decided to hold a national assembly in Rangoon to support the formation of an interim government, abolishment of the BSPP, and the disbanding of the election commission. The political crisis in Burma had reached critical mass.

On Sunday September 18, the military staged a coup establishing the State Law and Order Restoration Council (SLORC). The tatmadaw had become worried that members of the armed forces were starting to defect to the pro-democracy movement. The 1986 People's Power movement in the Philippines may have influenced the regime's actions at this time. The Marcos regime had been deposed mostly because of the decision by the military to side with the opposition. The day before the coup, the military issued a statement saying that the main duties of the armed forces remained: